



If
by
Rudyard Kipling



About the Author



Name	Rudyard Kipling
Born & died	December 30, 1865 - January 18, 1936
Place of birth	Bombay, India
Profession	Poet, Novelist, Journalist and children's book author (Jungle Book)
Literary period	Victorian
Achievement	Won Nobel Prize in Literature in 1907

The Poem

Type of work	A prolific journalist, poet, and writer of short stories and novels
Written	around 1895 or 1896
Published	1910
Main Theme(s)	Living a virtuous and honorable life, focusing on self-discipline, integrity, and resilience in the face of life's challenges

Short Question Answers

Q. No-1 How does Kiplin suggest one should deal with both success and failure?

Ans. Rudyard Kipling suggests that one should treat both success and failure calmly and equally. In the poem "If", he calls them "two impostors," meaning they are temporary and not the true measure of a person's worth. Kipling advises not to be proud when successful or broken when failing. Instead, one should stay balanced, learn from both experiences, and keep moving forward. This attitude helps a person remain strong and wise in every situation.

Q. No- 2 Why does the poet consider "triumph and Disaster" as "imposters"? Justify with some reasons.

Ans. The poet calls "Triumph and Disaster" impostors because they are not permanent and can easily mislead a person. Success may make someone proud, while failure may make them lose hope, but both are temporary moments in life. Kipling believes neither should control our emotions or actions. By calling them impostors, he reminds us that they only appear real but do not define our true worth. A wise person stays calm in both situations and learns from them.

Q. No- 3 Which quality described in the poem do you find most challenging to uphold in your own life, and why?

Ans. The most challenging quality for me to uphold is staying calm and patient when everything around me goes wrong. It is difficult not to lose control or react in anger when situations feel unfair or stressful. Kipling's advice to "keep your head when all about you are losing theirs" sounds simple but is hard to follow. It requires strong self-control and trust in oneself. I find this quality challenging because emotions often overpower reason, yet it is the one that brings true strength and peace.

Q. No- 4 What is the significance of maintaining one's integrity while interacting with both "crowds" and "kings"?

Ans. The poet advises maintaining integrity with both "crowds" and "kings" to stay honest and humble in all situations. It means treating everyone with respect, whether they are ordinary people or powerful leaders. Kipling highlights that true character is shown when a person's values do not change with status or company. One should not look down on the poor or flatter the rich. By keeping integrity, a person earns real respect and trust from all, showing fairness and dignity in every relationship.

Q. No- 5 Why does the poet place emphasis on patience, truthfulness, and self-discipline in achieving personal growth?

Ans. The poet emphasizes patience, truthfulness, and self-discipline because they help build strong character and lasting success. Patience teaches us to face challenges calmly, truthfulness keeps our actions honest, and self-discipline guides us to stay focused on our goals. Kipling believes these qualities help a person grow wiser and stronger from every experience. Without them, success is temporary and character becomes weak. Together, they shape a balanced, confident, and responsible individual who can handle life's ups and downs with courage and wisdom.

Literary Devices:

1. Anaphora (Repetition at the beginning of lines)

Definition: Repetition of a word or phrase at the start of successive lines or clauses.

Example:

"If you can keep your head when all about you..."

"If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you..."

"If you can wait and not be tired by waiting..."

Effect: Creates rhythm, unity, and emphasis on the poem's central conditional theme — each "If" builds toward the final reward.

4. Personification

Definition: Giving human qualities to abstract concepts or non-human things.

Example:

"Triumph and Disaster... those two impostors."

Effect: By calling them "impostors," Kipling humanizes success and failure, showing that neither should control one's spirit.

5. Metaphor

Definition: An indirect comparison between two unlike things.

Examples:

- “If you can fill the unforgiving minute / With sixty seconds’ worth of distance run.”
→ *Time is compared to a race.*
- “Your heart and nerve and sinew...”
→ *Symbolize inner strength and endurance.*

Effect: Gives abstract ideas (like time and resilience) vivid imagery and meaning.

6. Paradox

Definition: A statement that seems contradictory but reveals truth.

Example:

“If all men count with you, but none too much.”

Effect: Emphasizes moderation and balance — valuing everyone, yet not depending too heavily on anyone.

7. Alliteration

Definition: Repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of nearby words.

Examples:

“If you **can keep** your head...”

Effect: Adds musicality and rhythm to the poem.

8. Symbolism

Definition: Using objects, ideas, or actions to represent deeper meanings.

Examples:

- “Triumph and Disaster” → symbolize success and failure.

“The unforgiving minute” → symbolizes the value of time.

Effect: Enriches the poem’s moral lesson about life and maturity.

10. Hyperbole (Exaggeration)

Example:

“If you can fill the unforgiving minute / With sixty seconds’ worth of distance run.”

Effect: Stresses the idea of making the most of every moment — living life to the fullest.

11. Didactic Tone

Definition: A tone intended to teach or give moral instruction.

Effect: The poem reads like a father’s advice to his son — guiding him toward maturity, self-control, and moral integrity.

Meanings and synonyms of the words/phrases extracted from the poem “If”:

1. Allowance

- **Meaning:** A sum of money given regularly; permission or tolerance for something.
- **Synonyms:** Allocation, stipend, grant, permit, concession, permission.

2. Common Touch

- **Meaning:** The ability of someone in a position of power or prominence to relate to and appeal to ordinary people.
- **Synonyms:** Approachability, humility, accessibility, down-to-earth quality.

3. Deal in

- **Meaning:** To buy and sell a particular product or type of product; to be involved or concerned with something.
- **Synonyms:** Consider, Trade in, engage in, handle, understand, operate in.

4. Heap

- **Meaning:** A large pile or mass of something; to put things in a pile or gather in large quantities.
- **Synonyms:** Pile, stack, mound, accumulation, load.

5. Imposters

- **Meaning:** People who pretend to be someone else to deceive others.
- **Synonyms:** Fraud, pretender, con artist, deceiver, charlatan.

6. Knaves

- **Meaning:** Dishonest or unscrupulous men; a term used in older English to mean a male servant.
- **Synonyms:** Rogue, scoundrel, rascal, villain, trickster.

7. Sinew

- **Meaning:** A piece of tough tissue connecting muscle to bone; strength, resilience, or the mainstay of something.
- **Synonyms:** Tendon, ligament, strength, vigor, power.

8. Stoop

- **Meaning:** To bend the body forward or downward; to lower oneself morally or socially.
- **Synonyms:** Bend, crouch, hunch, bow, lower oneself.

9. Triumph

- **Meaning:** A great victory or achievement; to achieve a victory or success.
- **Synonyms:** Victory, success, accomplishment, conquest, win.

10. Virtue

- **Meaning:** Behavior showing high moral standards; a desirable or good quality.
- **Synonyms:** Morality, integrity, goodness, merit, righteousness.

11. Worn-out

- **Meaning:** Exhausted or fatigued; damaged or shabby due to overuse.
- **Synonyms:** Exhausted, tired, shabby, old, dilapidated, threadbare.

10 multiple-choice questions (MCQs) from the poem “If” by Rudyard Kipling

1. What does the poet mean by “keep your head when all about you are losing theirs”?
A) To stay silent when others are talking
B) To remain calm in times of trouble
C) To agree with everyone’s opinion
D) To avoid taking responsibility
2. The phrase “trust yourself when all men doubt you” encourages which quality?
A) Overconfidence
B) Self-belief
C) Pride
D) Rebellion
3. In the poem, “Triumph and Disaster” are called “impostors” because they are:
A) Real and lasting
B) False and temporary
C) Dangerous and unavoidable
D) Hard to understand
4. What does the poet advise when people twist your words to trap you?
A) Argue with them
B) Stay silent
C) Rebuild the truth calmly
D) Avoid those people forever

5. "If you can wait and not be tired by waiting" teaches the value of:
- A) Determination
 - B) Patience
 - C) Laziness
 - D) Silence
6. What should a person do when faced with lies, according to the poem?
- A) Ignore the truth
 - B) React with anger
 - C) Remain truthful
 - D) Spread other lies
7. The poet's advice to "walk with kings—nor lose the common touch" means:
- A) Treat everyone with equality
 - B) Obey the powerful only
 - C) Avoid ordinary people
 - D) Follow the rich for success
8. The line "If you can fill the unforgiving minute with sixty seconds' worth of distance run" suggests:
- A) Use every moment wisely
 - B) Work without rest
 - C) Value money over time
 - D) Run fast in every race
9. According to the poem, how should one respond when dreams fail?
- A) Forget about them
 - B) Give up trying
 - C) Start new dreams with courage
 - D) Blame others for failure
10. The poem ends with the reward of:
- A) Fame and wealth
 - B) Becoming a complete human being
 - C) Winning everyone's respect
 - D) Gaining knowledge and wisdom

Answer key with justifications:

1. B) To remain calm in times of trouble

Justification: The poet advises keeping calm ("keep your head") when others panic, showing emotional control and composure.

2. B) Self-belief

Justification: "Trust yourself when all men doubt you" means having faith in your own judgment and abilities even when others don't.

3. B) False and temporary

Justification: Kipling calls Triumph and Disaster “impostors” because both success and failure are short-lived and can mislead people about their real worth.

4. C) Rebuild the truth calmly

Justification: The poet encourages staying composed and continuing to do right, even if others twist your words to deceive.

5. B) Patience

Justification: The line “If you can wait and not be tired by waiting” highlights patience as a vital strength during delays and struggles.

6. C) Remain truthful

Justification: Kipling teaches that one should not deal in lies even when surrounded by falsehoods, promoting honesty and integrity.

7. A) Treat everyone with equality

Justification: The poet advises mingling with kings without losing the “common touch,” meaning treat all people with respect regardless of status.

8. A) Use every moment wisely

Justification: The “unforgiving minute” symbolizes time; filling it with “sixty seconds’ worth of distance run” means making the best use of every moment.

9. C) Start new dreams with courage

Justification: The poem teaches resilience—if dreams break, don’t lose hope; rebuild and keep striving forward.

10. B) Becoming a complete human being

Justification: The poem concludes with “you’ll be a Man, my son!” meaning one who develops all noble human qualities—calm, courage, patience, and balance.

